1. *Commission of the European Communities:* This constitutes the executive wing of the European Union. It is a body composed of one appointee from each state, and at present there are 27 Commissioners. This body is to initiate proposal for legislation, to act as a “Guardian of the Treaties”, and to be the manager and executor of the EU policies and international trade relationships. But in dispensing all its functions, the Commission is designed to be independent of national interests. This body also has the responsibility of dealing with the day-to-day running of the EU.

The Commission is led by a President who is nominated by the Council, in practice the European Council, and approved by the European Parliament. The remaining Commissioners are proposed by the member states, in consultation with the President, and then have to be approved by the European Parliament as a whole before the Commission can take office. The present President José Manuel Barroso and his Commission was elected in 2004 and reelected in 2009 and have a mandate till October 2014.

2. *Council of the European Union:* This **Council of the European Union** is the principal decision-making institution of the European Union (EU). It is often informally called the **Council of Ministers** or just the **Council**. It is the more powerful of the two legislative chambers, the other being the European Parliament.

The Council is composed of 27 national ministers (one per state and one President-in-Office). However, the exact membership depends on the topic being discussed. The European Union’s law is limited to specific policy areas; however, it does override the national law. As the EU operates on supranational and intergovernmental platforms, in some areas the Council is superior to the Parliament, having only to consult in order to get assent from the body. In many areas, however, the EU uses the legislative process of co-decision procedure, in which the two bodies are equal in power. Its Presidency rotates between the states every six months, but every three Presidencies now cooperate on a common programme like a “triple-shared presidency”.

3. *European Parliament (EP):* It is the only directly elected parliamentary institution of the European Union (EU). It is the